

SK2223 Environmental Problems within Social Science

Course report

Spring semester 2024

The course is a mandatory course in the Master's Programme in Political Science: Environmental Governance and Behavior, and an elective course in the Master's Programme in European Studies and the Master's Programme in International Administration and Global Governance. It is given in the first module of the second semester, and awards 15HP upon completion.

The aim of the course is to give students the conceptual and theoretical tools to analyze environmental problems as a social scientist, both when it comes to explaining why these problems occur and solving them. The course is organized around three segments: the first covers explanatory perspectives on environmental problems, including collective action theory and neo-Malthusianism; the second covers the relationship between the political system and environmental performance; and the third covers green political theory. Unlike other courses in the master's programme, the course is fairly lecture intensive, and among other things offers guest lectures given by researchers from other fields than political science. Passing the course requires attending three seminars and achieving a sufficiently high cumulative score on three written assignments.

This was the third iteration. The course ran smoothly apart from a pair of cancelled lectures due to illness, but it was slightly less well received by the students than in 2023. Here are the results from the course evaluation (n= 25; 52 percent response rate)

Assessments, average between 1 (very bad) to 5 (very good)	Score 2023	Score 2024
Overall assessment of the course	4,4	4,2
... of lectures	4,5	4,3
... of teachers	4,6	4,3
... of the course literature	4,4	3,9
... of the seminars	4,4	4,5
... of the written assignments	4,2	4,2
... of the course's organization	4,7	4,1
... of the workload (5=not at all demanding; 1= much too demanding)	2,8	3,1

One should not read too much into changes this small given the small number of respondents, but from the text responses, it seems that the following things accounted for why the students were more lukewarm about the course than in previous semesters:

1. Complaints about the course being too theoretical
2. Complaints about the literature being outdated
3. Complaints about lecturers rushing through slides

1 is not much to do about seeing as this is a mainly theoretical and conceptual course. 2 is mainly directed at the book the students are supposed to review for paper 3, *Climate Change Justice* by Posner and Weisbach. This book is from 2010, and while that does not affect its philosophical arguments at all, it is understandable that students find it grating to read something so old. There is a need to find a new book, but preferable one which, like Posner and Weisbach's, is likely to challenge the students' own position. A working hypothesis might be that Ross Mittiga's new book could be a replacement, though this would maybe necessitate changing the lectures somewhat for part III of the course. An alternative idea is to abandon the idea of writing a book review, but several students once again mention in the course evaluation that they find this task challenging and rewarding. Complaint 3 will be handled by reminding teachers not to overstuff lectures. Going by the text responses, complaint 3 is what explains the lower grade for the course organization in 2024.

On the plus side, there is no mention of several of the things that were an issue in 2023 and fixed this time around. In particular, it seems to have paid off to better integrate Povitkina's lectures in part II with the preceding course on module 2 in the fall. The new setup of the seminars, where students are designated as discussants, seems to work well going by the things the students had to say about the seminar discussions. There are no signs of students gaming the grading system of the course in any flagrant way.

Completion rate

23 students registered on the course. Of these, 17 have passed the course at the time of writing. 12 students got VG and 5 students got G. This was a higher proportion of VG than usual.

Changes for future iterations of the course

The course has a well-functioning structure, and the content is generally deemed both interesting and intellectually stimulating by the students. However, these changes will be considered for the next iteration of the course.

- Given that the course will become an elective also in the general master programme, the current setup probably will not work unless the course receives more hours as the grading will become too onerous. The course would then have to choose between going for the current (lecture-heavy) setup but with fewer writing assignments or a less lecture-heavy setup with the current writing assignments. There are pros and cons to both setups, but it is worth noting that several students express a desire for more lectures rather than fewer already now.
- Look for a new book for paper 3.
- Think about the instructions, and possibly staffing, related to guest lectures.

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2024-05-14, Göran Duus-Otterström, course director